

WEST

EDITION 2026–27

INFO BOOKLET

For *Students*

Real work for proven founders, for academic credit.
How it works, what is expected and where it leads.

WEST VENTURES · AFFILIATED WITH AUSTIN CHRISTIAN UNIVERSITY

GOWEST.VENTURES

Cover: Emanuel Leutze, Westward the Course of Empire Takes Its Way, 1861 (study).

A LETTER

From the managing partners

Thank you for asking about West Ventures. This booklet is written for you, the student.

Here is the arrangement. You join a small team and do real work for a founder or operator who has built something. You are expected to deliver, and you are treated as someone who can. You earn academic credit for it. Students who deliver are given more responsibility the next term: first a seat on a team, then a team to lead, then, for a few, a Fellowship working directly on the companies the studio builds.

Everything in these pages is how the studio operates today. Where a detail is still being set, it says so. If something here does not answer your question, reply to the email this booklet came in and one of us will answer it.

Jake Oswald

MANAGING PARTNER

Lars Ostervold

MANAGING PARTNER

FOR STUDENTS

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This booklet is written for students. Four companion booklets cover the program for parents, founders and executives, high schools and universities.

01 · THE STUDIO

What West Ventures is

A venture studio affiliated with Austin Christian University.

West Ventures finds young people with exceptional ability, puts them to work for proven founders and operators, and builds companies with them. It does three things, and each one feeds the others.

I

Teams

Small teams of high school and college students work on real problems for founders and operators, for academic credit. Companies pay nothing.

II

Companies

When a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture.

III

Network

Partner high schools and universities send their best students. Founders, operators and investors bring the work.

23

Companies served by student teams so far

78

Students who have worked on a team

500

Partner schools planned by 2030

02 · THE MODEL

Kings and *cupbearers*



GUSTAVE DORÉ, NEHEMIAH VIEWS THE RUINS OF JERUSALEM'S WALLS, 1866. NEHEMIAH WAS CUPBEARER TO THE KING.

The thesis is not tied to an industry. The studio's advantage is its model: free work, done by a large group of the country's most capable young people, for the most experienced founders and operators.

The old words for the arrangement are kings and cupbearers. Kings are proven owners and operators with more opportunities than time. Cupbearers are capable young people who need real work and someone to learn from. The studio's job is to match them, at scale.

The arrangement works because each side gets what it lacks. Founders get capable help, at no cost, on work they have no time for. Students get real work, someone to learn from and academic credit. And when a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture. It expects to start about six companies a year this way.

03 · OPPORTUNITIES

Found, *not invented*



CHARLES WILLSON PEALE, THE EXHUMATION OF THE MASTODON, 1806–08.

An 18-year-old's business ideas are usually poor. That is not a lack of intelligence; it is a lack of information. Ask someone who has built three or four companies and they already have ideas for the fourth and fifth, and they can say where the opportunity is and why.

Great business opportunities are discovered, not invented. Like a paleontologist who knows where to dig, the people who find them have spent years in an industry and can see a need before anyone has named it.

So students do not start with their own ideas. They work on problems and opportunities that proven operators have already found, and learn to see them.

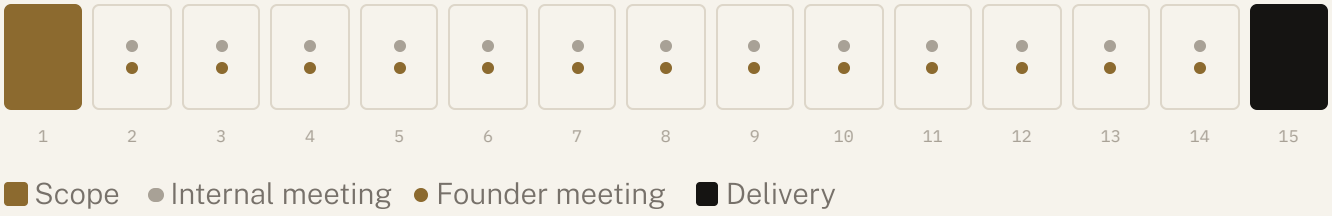
04 · HOW A PROJECT WORKS

How a project works

One team, one founder, one term, one written scope.

A project is one term of work by one team, for one founder or executive. Terms run in fall, spring and summer. The founder brings a real problem and about an hour a week. The company pays nothing and keeps all equity and intellectual property. Students earn academic credit.

A FALL OR SPRING TERM



Before	The studio matches the project with a team and a project lead, and introduces them to the founder.
Week one	The founder and the project lead write the scope: a week-by-week plan of what the team will deliver.
Every week	Two meetings. One internal, with the project lead, on tasks and blockers. One with the founder, to review the work and adjust the scope.
End of term	The team delivers and hands over. The project lead evaluates each student; the founder evaluates the project.
After	Students who delivered are invited back with more responsibility. An opportunity worth building may become a joint venture.

05 · THE TEAM

The team

About five students, an experienced project lead and the founder.



Two college students, one of whom leads the team.

Three high school Builder Scholars, nominated by their schools.

Teams mix students from different schools on purpose. Each team is coached by a volunteer project lead: an experienced professional who runs the internal meeting, keeps the scope honest and evaluates the work. Studio staff oversee every team.

TIME EACH WEEK

Team leader	College student	5 to 10 hours
Contributor	College student	4 to 8 hours
Builder Scholar	High school student	About 3 hours
Project lead	Volunteer professional	Two meetings, plus review
Founder	The company	About 1 hour

06 · EXPECTATIONS

What each party commits to

The arrangement works when everyone does their part. This is what each is asked to do.

Students

- Give the hours the role requires, every week.
- Attend both weekly meetings, prepared.
- Deliver what the scope says, when it says.
- Keep the company's information confidential.
- Represent the company and the studio well.

The founder

- Bring a real problem or opportunity that matters to the business.
- Write the scope with the project lead in week one.
- Meet the team once a week and answer questions in between.
- Give honest feedback, including when the work falls short.
- Evaluate the project at the end of the term.

The project lead

- Run the weekly internal meeting and coach the team.
- Keep the scope current and the founder informed.
- Hold students to the standard the founder expects.
- Evaluate each student's work at the end of the term.

The studio

- Recruit and screen students and project leads.
- Match each project with a team that can deliver it.
- Handle all academic paperwork and credit.
- Oversee every team and step in when a project is off track.

07 · THE WORK

The work

Every project falls into one or more of five kinds of work.

I	**Market research.** Customer interviews, market sizing and problem validation.
II	**Agentic engineering.** Websites, apps, internal tools and AI agents.
III	**Branding.** Names, logos, visual identity and messaging.
IV	**Marketing.** Photo, video, copywriting and paid advertising.
V	**Sales.** Lead lists, outreach and customer pipeline.



LIFETIME FITNESS · HEALTH & FITNESS CLUBS



OVERFLOW · GENEROSITY PLATFORM



BURLEBO · OUTDOOR APPAREL BRAND

08 · OUTCOMES FOR STUDENTS

Outcomes for students

Responsibility is earned one term at a time.

01	**Builder Scholar.** A high school student on a team, nominated by their school. Earns college credit.
02	**Contributor.** A college student on a team, doing a defined part of the scope.
03	**Team leader.** Invited after a strong term. Leads the team day to day and answers to the founder.
04	**Fellow.** The studio's most trusted students. Fellows work directly with proven operators on the studio's own companies, two or three at a time.

78

Students who have worked on a team

21

Student Fellows named

2×

Gloo AI Hackathon won by ACU student teams, 2025 and 2026

Every student keeps a record of the work: a public profile listing each company they worked for, their role and what the team delivered, alongside academic credit on a transcript and a reference from a project lead who saw the work.

09 · FROM FOUNDERS

From founders

"Cole has been outstanding on our startup — smart, technically capable, coachable, hardworking, and a true team player. His contribution reflects not only strong technical skill, but the character, humility, and mission-minded leadership ACU is developing in its students."

Paul Kent Graeve
Founder & CEO, Today Matters

"I've spent years working in Big Tech in Silicon Valley with the world's most premiere talent. The profile of the ACU student is unique. The world has a lot of knowledge, but it needs more wisdom. ACU students are showcasing a rigorously intellectual foundation coupled with a moral, Christian fabric — a combo the world desperately needs more of. I wouldn't hesitate to bring an ACU student on."

John Kronlokken
Founder & CEO, Evergreen / Ex-Corporate Strategy, Google

"As an entrepreneur, I wish I had the college experience that ACU is creating. ACU provides students the opportunities they need to become excellent, and the students are delivering on that opportunity. Coming into the engagement, I thought it would be predominantly mentorship. I was wrong. The students delivered tangible value to our organization the whole way through. Movements like this will inspire the next generation of leaders to believe God is in all things, including our work."

Anthony Ruffner
Founder & CEO, Turn

10 · FROM FAMILIES AND TEACHERS

From families and teachers

PARENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from the parent of a Builder Scholar: what changed in their son or daughter over a term."

Name
Parent of a Fall 2026 Builder Scholar

TEACHER TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a teacher or counselor who nominated students: why they nominated them and what came back."

Name
Teacher, partner high school

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a Builder Scholar about the work they did and who they did it for."

Name
Builder Scholar, Fall 2026

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a college team leader about leading a team for a founder."

Name
Team leader, Fall 2026

Families and teachers who would speak with a prospective family directly can be introduced on request.

11 · PRICING

Pricing

$5,000

per student, per term.

The same price for high school and college students, who work on the same teams. Companies, partner schools and universities pay nothing.

Terms	Fall, spring and summer. Each is priced and enrolled separately.
A full year	$15,000 for all three terms.
Credit	3 to 6 credit hours a term, awarded through Austin Christian University.
Included	Team placement, a project lead, and academic credit and its paperwork.
Scholarships	Need-based scholarships are available. Price should not keep a capable student out.
Effective	Summer 2027 and later. Earlier terms are priced under the current program.

ONE TERM

$5,000

3 to 6 credit hours

FALL AND SPRING

$10,000

6 to 12 credit hours

FULL YEAR

$15,000

9 to 18 credit hours

12 · STUDY ABROAD

A term *abroad*

Through Living and Learning International, students can live overseas for a term and stay on a team.

Living and Learning International is a faith-based study abroad provider that works with more than forty Christian colleges and universities. Students live in residential communities with resident staff, take courses whose credit transfers home, and live in the culture. West Ventures students can spend a term in one of its locations and keep working with their team remotely, building companies from wherever they are.

Quito *Ecuador*	0.18° S · 78.47° W
Rome *Italy*	41.90° N · 12.50° E
London *England*	51.51° N · 0.13° W

TO CONFIRM Locations, dates and costs are set by Living and Learning and confirmed with each student before a term abroad. Living and Learning's program fees are separate from West Ventures tuition.

13 · QUESTIONS

Questions

Do I need experience?

No. You need to show that you can learn quickly and do what you say you will do. Teams include students with no prior experience alongside students with a lot.

Can I bring my own idea?

Not usually. Students work on opportunities that experienced operators have already found. Students who want to build their own company learn more, faster, by first working for someone who has done it.

What kind of work will I do?

One of five kinds: market research, software and AI engineering, branding, marketing, or sales. The scope is written in the first week of the term.

How is my work graded?

On the work itself. There are no tests. Your project lead evaluates what you delivered against the scope.

Can I do this from anywhere?

Yes. Teams work remotely. With Living and Learning International you can spend a term abroad and stay on a team.

What happens after a good term?

Students who deliver are invited back with more responsibility: contributor, then team leader, then Fellow.

14 · NEXT STEPS

Next steps

1

Apply

College students apply directly. High school students are nominated by their school or apply directly. Reply to the email this booklet came in to start.

2

Interview

A short conversation with the studio about what you have done and what you want to learn.

3

Join a team

Accepted students are placed on a team before the term begins and meet their founder in week one.

CONTACT

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WEST

VENTURES

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